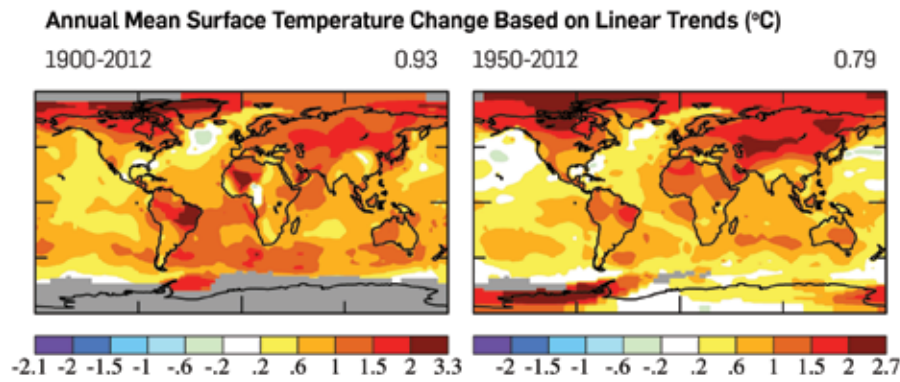




Annual Mean Surface temperatures

if you're not careful, you'll irreparably damage your speakers as well. The mic didn't start the loop, but it did perpetuate it. Now consider that same experiment carried out in your home, or at a noisy party. The background noise will only help to accelerate the process. Oversimplifying the process to a large extent, this is how global warming works. The mic is CO₂ (and other greenhouse gasses of course) and the speakers represent the Earth. Even if we are not responsible for causing global warming, we are responsible for perpetuating it and that is why action must be taken as soon as humanly possible to cut down on greenhouse gas emissions.

Carbon credits: What are they worth?

Close to nothing. Not in terms of cash, but in terms of the environmental impact that this system has. You've all heard this term many times and many of you might already be familiar with it. To those not in the know, here is a quick summary: A carbon credit is a sort of certificate that states that an entity has the right to emit greenhouse gases that are equivalent in

impact to one tonne of CO₂. The system was put into place in the Kyoto protocol and was seen as one of the first steps in cutting down greenhouse gas emissions.

The logic behind this model is that a company or entity that cannot or will not take the trouble to go "green" or at least carbon neutral will have to buy carbon credits from some other entity that has gone green so as to offset their own greenhouse gas emissions. This other entity need not necessarily be a company that has gone green; it can even be a government or a company that has heavily invested in, say, CO₂ sinks that will soak up CO₂, or maybe even an entity that is involved in reforestation. If you've got a cattle farm of your own, you can generate carbon credits yourself by capturing and selling all that naturally produced methane. Methane is a greenhouse gas, but it's still less polluting than oil and can thus, generate carbon credits. Unfortunately, this system is inherently flawed. Carbon credits are not really enforced to the degree that they should be. Also, supposing a power station is generating a million tonnes of CO₂ a year and they reduce emissions

by a 100,000 tonnes. They actually get a 100,000 carbon credits rather than being penalised for still generating 900,000 tonnes of CO₂. Of course, we're not saying that a power station has to be penalized for something that it's commissioned to do and sure, some motivation is better than no motivation. But the bottom line is simply this, 900,000 tonnes of CO₂ is still being pumped into the atmosphere and there is nothing being done about it.

The whole system is being looked at more as a sort of stock market, the BitCoin phenomenon if you will, rather than as a legitimate means of enforcing "green" consciousness and environmental reform. Actual businesses that deal exclusively in carbon credits have erupted around this concept and at their roots, most of those businesses are no different from traditional investment firms.

The major flaw with this system is the fact that it doesn't seem to affect us, as average citizens. We're not penalized for running power hungry PCs with three monitors or leaving a torrent-box running for weeks on end. We don't see a "carbon tax" on the foodstuffs that we buy or the gadgets that we purchase. As geeks, we're probably the most polluting members of the human race in terms of the average citizen. We want our power-hungry PCs, our mobiles, tablets, gaming consoles and laptops and we don't spend a rupee on carbon credits.

The system might seem to be having an impact on the environment and as we said earlier, something really is better than nothing. But it isn't enough. It's just a very convoluted method of assuaging our collective consciences by pretending that we've done something to contribute.

Harsh realities

There is no magical cure to global warming. If it really is a natural phenomenon then we're just exceptionally arrogant if we think that we have the power to impact our planet in such a way. That said, we have it in our power to safeguard ourselves against the more harmful effects of this phenomenon and we're just being foolish if we don't do something about it. We've covered green energy vs. oil in parts of this cover story. Read on to find out about the true state of power in this world. 

